PROactive PRONUNCIATION

“AA” Spelling

In terms of spelling, the/æ/ is represented with an “a” most of the time. Unfortunately, the “a” spelling can be pronounced in various ways. For the most part, however, this rule will help you identify the “a” in stressed syllables with no other vowels next to it. If other vowels sit beside the “a,” like in “bear,” or have a silent “e” at the ends of the words, like in “care,” then other rules apply, so be careful.

Spelling:

“a” 97% of words

“al” as in half/calf 1.5% of words

“au” as in laugh 1.5% of words

“ai” as in “plaid” (exception word)

Here is a simple two-part rule that can help!

1. In a stressed syllable, the letter "a" is pronounced as /æ/.
   - **a**pple
   - **fa**ster
   - **pla**ster
2. In a one-syllable word, the letter "a" is pronounced as /æ/, unless the word ends with the letter "e."
   - m**a**t
   - h**a**t
   - t**a**p would all be /æ/

   - but mat**e**
   - hat**e**
   - tap**e** would not, they would be /ei/ “eh eee”